EVACUATIONS AND LANDINGS

OPERATIONS IN SUPPORT of land forces constituted a major part of the naval war in the European theater. In April 1940 the Germans landed troops in Norway, primarily by sea, precipitating an intensive air-sea battle as Britain and France attempted first to interrupt the landings and then to put their own soldiers ashore. Both sides suffered naval losses in the Norway campaign, which ended in victory for Germany in June. By then the Germans had invaded France and the Low Countries, forcing a mass evacuation of Allied troops from Dunkirk, carried off by Royal Navy warships with the assistance of a flotilla of small craft under intensive air attack. From 1942, however, with the United States in the war and the tide of victory flowing in the opposite direction, Allied naval forces developed expertise in troop landings rather than evacuations. After British and American warships had successfully escorted troops to North Africa in late 1942, they went on to cover the landings in Sicily and southern Italy in the following year, and finally played a crucial role in achieving the vast-scale invasion of Normandy in June 1944.

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NARVIK



Date April 10–13, 1940
Forces British: 1 carrier, 1 battleship, 14 destroyers; Germans: 10 destroyers
Losses British: 2 destroyers, 2 aircraft; Germans: 10 destroyers, 1 U-boat
Location Narvik, Ofotfjord, Norway

Early in the Norway campaign, Captain Bernard Warburton-Lee, in command of a destroyer flotilla, decided to attack a German naval force in port at Narvik, which was outside the range of Luftwaffe air cover. He took his five H-class destroyers—*Hardy*, *Hotspur*, *Havock*, *Hunter*, and *Hostile*—stealthily up the Ofotfjord in a heavy snowstorm, approaching Narvik at dawn. The Germans had taken a picket ship off station and were caught by surprise. Two German destroyers were sunk and three others damaged. Having sunk some cargo ships and exchanged fire with German forces on shore, Warburton-Lee then set to leave, but on the way out he was surprised by five more German destroyers that had been concealed around the fjord. *Hardy* and *Hunter* were lost and *Hotspur* severely damaged. Killed on board *Hardy*, Warburton-Lee was awarded a posthumous Victoria Cross.

Three days later the Royal Navy sent the battleship *Warspite*, escorted by destroyers and supported by the carrier *Furious*, to Narvik. The eight German destroyers still in the fjord, several damaged and all short of fuel and ammunition, were annihilated by this overwhelming force. Troops were then landed at Narvik, but had to be evacuated two months later as Norway became indefensible.

WORLD WAR II

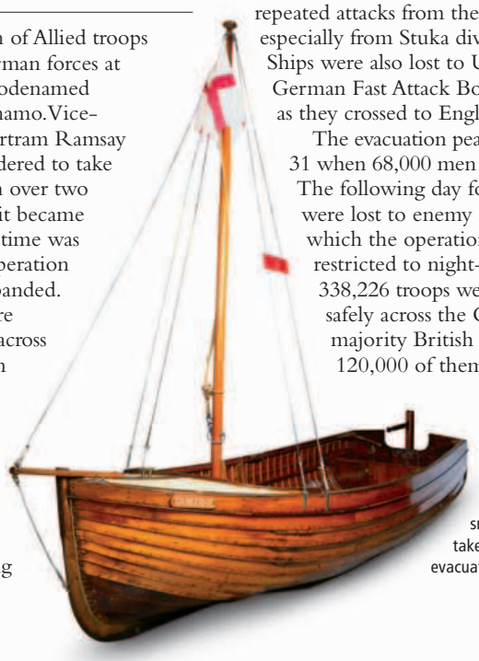
DUNKIRK



Date May 4-June 26, 1940
Forces Allies: 222 naval vessels, 665 civilian craft
Losses British: 6 destroyers, 24 other naval vessels, c.200 small craft; French: 3 destroyers
Location Dunkirk, northern France

The evacuation of Allied troops trapped by German forces at Dunkirk was codenamed Operation Dynamo. Vice-Admiral Sir Bertram Ramsay was initially ordered to take off 45,000 men over two days, but once it became apparent more time was available, the operation was greatly expanded. The troops were mostly carried across the Channel on destroyers and minesweepers, but Ramsay also called for the aid of hundreds of small civilian vessels including paddle steamers, trawlers, tugboats, and lifeboats. This was not a pure improvisation—most of the boats belonged to the Royal Navy's "small vessels pool." The function of the little boats was to ferry soldiers from the Dunkirk beaches through the shallows to naval ships waiting off shore, since Dunkirk port had become unusable. The evacuation was carried out under repeated attacks from the Luftwaffe, especially from Stuka dive-bombers. Ships were also lost to U-boats and German Fast Attack Boats (E-boats) as they crossed to England.

The evacuation peaked on May 31 when 68,000 men were rescued. The following day four destroyers were lost to enemy attack, after which the operation was restricted to night-time. In all 338,226 troops were brought safely across the Channel, the majority British but some 120,000 of them French.



Dunkirk little ship At only 15 ft (4.5 m) long, *Tamzine* was the smallest vessel to take part in the evacuation of Dunkirk.

